MODULE 49 · EXAM STRATEGY - ALL DOMAINS

Confusion Pairs

Thirty pairs, six per domain, each divided by one property. Learn the divider, not two definitions.

DOMAIN Cross-cutting EXAM WEIGHT All five MODULE 49 of 52

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For each pair, one property decides. **Learn the divider**, and the definitions stop mattering.

Domain 1: architecture

PAIR	THE PROPERTY THAT DIVIDES THEM
FIFO queue vs Kinesis	One worker pool vs several readers or replay
Step Functions Standard vs Express	Waits and callbacks vs millions of short runs
Service Connect vs VPC Lattice	ECS only vs mixed compute, VPCs, IAM auth
Bedrock Agents vs AgentCore	Built in Bedrock vs your framework, model or MCP
RAG vs customised model	Changing facts and citations vs behaviour
Lake Formation vs Clean Rooms	Partner sees records vs only permitted results

ON THE EXAM

AI pairs are new to C03, and the RAG divider is the one most often missed.

Domain 2: security

PAIR	THE PROPERTY THAT DIVIDES THEM
SCP vs RCP	Follows the identity vs follows the resource
User pool vs identity pool	Who you are vs AWS credentials
Client VPN vs Verified Access	Network access vs per-app with device posture
ML-KEM vs ML-DSA	Keeps data secret vs proves origin
Grounding vs Automated Reasoning	Supported by a source vs checked against rules
Residency vs sovereignty	Regions and policy vs operating model

ON THE EXAM

Neither an SCP nor an RCP grants anything, and neither affects the management account.

Domain 3: cost

PAIR	THE PROPERTY THAT DIVIDES THEM
Savings Plan vs capacity reservation	Discount vs guaranteed launch
Budgets vs Cost Anomaly Detection	Known limit vs surprise
Showback vs chargeback	Visibility vs a bill teams must accept
Prompt routing vs distillation	Mixed difficulty vs one task at huge volume
Longer TTLs vs Origin Shield	Repeat requests vs misses from many locations
Lambda vs Managed Instances	Spiky vs steady, very high volume

ON THE EXAM

A Savings Plan never guarantees capacity. For a launch event, reserve, then cover it with a plan.

Domain 4: resilience and migration

PAIR	THE PROPERTY THAT DIVIDES THEM
Pilot light vs warm standby	Core off vs running, scaled down
Route 53 failover vs Global Accelerator	DNS TTLs vs fixed IPs, no caching
Agent vs agentless replication	Software allowed in the guest or not
Rehost to EC2 vs relocate to EVS	Change operations vs keep VMware as is
Replatform vs refactor	Less to run vs new capabilities
Mainframe refactor vs reimagine	Change the language vs change the design

ON THE EXAM

Clients that allow-list IPs or ignore DNS TTLs rule out DNS failover.

Domain 5: operations

PAIR	THE PROPERTY THAT DIVIDES THEM
CloudFormation Hook vs Config rule	At deployment vs any resource, afterwards
Template drift vs policy drift	Drift-aware change set vs Config remediation
Canary vs blue/green	Smallest exposure vs fastest return
Synthetics vs RUM	Before users notice vs what real users see
Cross-account observability vs subscriptions	View in place vs copy out
Data quality vs model quality monitor	Inputs only vs correctness, needs labels

ON THE EXAM

Hooks never see console or CLI changes. Anything created by hand needs Config.

How to use these under exam pressure

- **Name the pair** the question is testing before reading the options.
- **Find the word that resolves it**: never, guarantee, automatically, existing, a number.
- **Two plausible options usually means one pair.** The other two fill the page.
- If both members still seem right, you have the wrong pair. Read the requirement again.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Composite questions combine two pairs. Each one eliminates two options.

> An insurer has a claims agent built with LangGraph that holds conversations lasting up to an hour. It wants to run the agent on managed AWS infrastructure without rewriting it.
>
> The agent must answer from policy documents that change weekly, and cite the clause it used.

Which combination should the solutions architect choose?

A. Fine-tune a model on the documents each week, and rebuild the agent in Bedrock Agents

B. A Bedrock knowledge base, and rebuild the agent in Bedrock Agents

C. A Bedrock knowledge base for retrieval, with the existing agent hosted on AgentCore Runtime

D. Fine-tune a model each week, with the existing agent hosted on AgentCore Runtime

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

Which combination should the solutions architect choose?

A Fine-tune, Bedrock Agents

Both halves wrong: no citations, and a rewrite.

B Knowledge base, Bedrock Agents

Right on RAG, but rewrites the agent.

C Knowledge base, AgentCore

RAG gives citations; AgentCore runs LangGraph, long sessions.

D Fine-tune, AgentCore

Right on hosting; weekly facts and citations need RAG.

THE SIGNAL

Two pairs: RAG versus customisation, and Bedrock Agents versus AgentCore.

> A payments processor needs recovery in a second Region within 10 minutes. The recovery Region must be running and able to accept traffic immediately, then scale up.
>
> Card networks connect to fixed IP addresses on their allow-lists, and some of their systems ignore DNS TTLs.

Which design should the solutions architect choose?

A. Warm standby in the second Region, with Global Accelerator in front of both Regions

B. Pilot light in the second Region, with Global Accelerator

C. Warm standby, with Route 53 failover records

D. Pilot light, with Route 53 failover records

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

Which design should the solutions architect choose?

A. Warm standby, Global Accelerator
Running copy; fixed IPs, no DNS caching.

B. Pilot light, Global Accelerator
Core is off; cannot take traffic at once.

C. Warm standby, Route 53
New IPs and cached DNS break the card networks.

D. Pilot light, Route 53
Both halves fail.

THE SIGNAL

Two pairs: pilot light versus warm standby, and DNS failover versus anycast.

> A retailer runs 12 teams on one shared EKS cluster with GPU nodes. Finance will start billing each team for its share, so teams must accept the allocation as fair.
>
> Finance also wants to hear about unusual spikes in any team's spend, without setting a threshold for each team.

What should the solutions architect recommend?

A. Tag each node group by team, and set AWS Budgets per team

B. A showback dashboard of node costs, and Cost Anomaly Detection

C. Split cost allocation data for EKS, and AWS Budgets per team

D. Split cost allocation data for EKS, and Cost Anomaly Detection monitors by team cost category

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should the solutions architect recommend?

A Node tags, Budgets

Shared nodes cannot be tagged per team; thresholds needed.

B Showback, anomaly

Showback is not a bill teams accept.

C Split cost, Budgets

Fair allocation, but Budgets need thresholds.

D Split cost, anomaly detection

Measured usage, and alerts with no thresholds.

THE SIGNAL

Two pairs: showback versus chargeback, and Budgets versus Cost Anomaly Detection.

> A travel company is releasing a new booking API. It wants the new version exposed to as few real customers as possible at first, reverting automatically if errors rise.
>
> It also wants to know within minutes if the overnight booking journey breaks, when almost nobody is online.

Which combination should the solutions architect choose?

A Blue/green deployment, with CloudWatch RUM

B Canary deployment with alarm rollback, with a CloudWatch Synthetics canary on the booking journey

C Blue/green deployment, with a Synthetics canary

D Canary deployment with alarm rollback, with CloudWatch RUM

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

Which combination should the solutions architect choose?

A Blue/green, RUM

Everyone moves at the switch; RUM is silent at night.

B Canary, Synthetics

Small slice first; checks the journey with no users.

C Blue/green, Synthetics

Right monitor, but no small first exposure.

D Canary, RUM

Right strategy, but RUM needs real users.

THE SIGNAL

Two pairs: canary versus blue/green, and Synthetics versus RUM.

A device maker must sign firmware so that devices can verify its origin, and the signatures must resist future quantum attacks.

Unreleased firmware sits in S3. No principal outside the organisation may ever read it, even if a developer misconfigures a bucket policy.

Which combination should the solutions architect choose?

A. An ML-KEM key in AWS KMS, and a resource control policy limiting access to the organisation

B. An ML-DSA key in AWS KMS for signing, and a resource control policy limiting access to the organisation

C. An ML-DSA key in AWS KMS, and a service control policy on developer accounts

D. An ML-KEM key in AWS KMS, and a service control policy on developer accounts

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

Which combination should the solutions architect choose?

A ML-KEM, RCP

ML-KEM establishes secrets; it does not sign.

B ML-DSA, RCP

Quantum-resistant signatures; the RCP caps the bucket.

C ML-DSA, SCP

An SCP limits your identities, not outsiders.

D ML-KEM, SCP

Both halves fail.

THE SIGNAL

Two pairs: ML-KEM versus ML-DSA, and SCP versus RCP.

> A retailer and an advertiser want to measure how many of the retailer's customers saw a campaign. Neither may see the other's customer records.
>
> Separately, the retailer's own analysts may only query certain columns of the customer tables in its data lake.

What should the solutions architect use for each need?

A Lake Formation for both needs

B AWS Clean Rooms for both needs

C Share the S3 bucket with the advertiser, and IAM policies for analysts

D AWS Clean Rooms with the advertiser, and Lake Formation column permissions for analysts

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should the solutions architect use for each need?

A Lake Formation for both

Sharing would expose records to the advertiser.

B Clean Rooms for both

Internal analysts need governed access, not a collaboration.

C Bucket share, IAM

Exposes raw data; IAM cannot filter columns.

D Clean Rooms and Lake Formation

Results only for the partner; columns for analysts.

THE SIGNAL

One pair, used twice: partner results only, internal fine-grained access.

What to carry out of this module

- **Name the pair before reading the options.** Most questions are one of about thirty.
- **Learn the divider**, not two definitions.
- **Composite questions resolve independently.** Two pairs leave one answer.
- If both members still seem right, re-read the requirement, not the options.

> ON THE EXAM
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> Most missed in C03: RAG versus customisation, ML-KEM versus ML-DSA, SCP versus RCP, Hooks versus Config.